

Talking Politics on the Job: How Corporate Activism Shapes Political Participation

Kevin Angell* and Isaac D. Mehlhaff†

July 2, 2026

Abstract

As civil society organizations decline and become more politically homogeneous, work remains one of the main environments where Americans communicate across political lines. At the same time, corporations have shown greater willingness to take public stances on political issues and to promote political causes among their employees. We use a national survey of American workers and two tailored survey experiments to assess the consequences of these developments on citizens' political participation both inside and outside the workplace. Despite workers' distaste for firms' political involvement, we show that corporate activism mobilizes employees to engage in politics. This mobilization is particularly strong when employees and employers are politically aligned or when the employer's message is politically neutral, while there is little evidence of a chilling effect among politically cross-pressured employees. Results suggest that firms can influence the amount and composition of mass political participation with relatively subtle messaging.

*PhD Candidate, Program in Political Economy, The University of Chicago; kevinjangell@uchicago.edu. Kevin Angell thanks the Chicago Forum for Free Inquiry and Expression for generous financial support. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship Program under Grant No. 214001. Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation.

†Neubauer Family Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science, The University of Chicago; imehlhaff@uchicago.edu; word count: 10,823.

Foundational public opinion scholarship in the mid-twentieth century recognized workplaces as crucial sites where social and occupational status shaped political attitudes (Berelson et al. 1954; Campbell et al. 1960).¹ More than six decades later, the workplace is as important to American politics as ever before. Following *Citizens United v. Federal Election Commission* (558 U.S. 310, 2010), corporations have been free to dedicate effectively unlimited resources to support their preferred causes. Beyond these financial channels, businesses frequently take public stances on political issues, engage in politically controversial actions, and promote political causes among their employees—even on issues ostensibly irrelevant to their core mission.

Although corporations have perhaps never been more involved in politics, scholarly focus on politics in the workplace has ebbed and flowed since the Columbia and Michigan schools made their seminal contributions. Theoretical emphasis on occupational prestige (e.g. Stevens and Featherman 1981) has largely given way to social class, the American National Election Studies stopped collecting occupation data in 2004, and scholars' current understanding of politics in the workplace centers on the top-down influence of labor unions in blue-collar occupations or of corporations in white-collar ones (e.g. Lyon et al. 2024; Steel 2026). In particular, contemporary scholars lack a detailed understanding of how corporate political activism affects employees, whether it exacerbates political or social divides, and how it has been affected by the paradigm shift engendered by *Citizens United*.

Employers often try to mobilize their employees for political causes, but such explicit efforts are deeply unpopular, toe the line of legality, and risk backlash from customers and employees alike (e.g. Frye et al. 2025; Hertel-Fernandez 2018). We theorize that firms attempt to circumvent the potentially negative effects of overt workplace mobilization by engaging in “softer” strategies of influence, namely, the forms of corporate activism that have been growing in recent years (Burbano 2021; Hersh and Shah forthcoming; McKean and King 2024). We argue that despite being indirect and comparatively subtle, corporate activism has a mobilizing effect on employees' polit-

¹For a more contemporary treatment, see Kitschelt and Rehm (2014).

ical participation—particularly their willingness to discuss politics at work—by signaling which political topics and stances are acceptable in the workplace or critical for the firm’s success.

We also theorize that these effects are conditional on the employer’s message and its congruence with employees’ preexisting attitudes. Mobilization should be strongest when employees perceive alignment between their own attitudes or identities and the firm’s political stance, as value congruence enhances the degree to which corporate messaging resonates with employees (Ashforth and Mael 1989; Burbano 2021). When the firm’s message runs counter to employees’ attitudes, however, employees may feel alienated or fear retaliation for voicing an opinion contrary to their employer’s position (Frye et al. 2025), resulting in a chilling effect on political participation.

We begin by presenting descriptive evidence from an original survey of American workers. Existing evidence of ideological heterogeneity in discussion networks largely pre-dates the hyper-partisan turn in American politics (e.g. Conover et al. 2002; Huckfeldt et al. 2004; Mutz 2006) and contemporary updates to this literature have been rare (Mutz 2025). We show that employees talk politics with their coworkers at much lower rates than they do with family and friends. However, they tend to participate more when their employers engage in political activism, despite disliking such activism. We also find workers who are politically cross-pressured by their employers are particularly likely to feel uncomfortable with politics in the workplace but, interestingly, are no less likely to engage their coworkers in political talk.

We then present two tailored survey experiments that test the causal effects of corporate activism on employees’ political participation. We find ideologically neutral mentions of political issues by firms can promote participation among employees. In contrast, statements advocating for a specific policy position encourage discussion among like-minded employees while producing only a modest chilling effect on those who disagree with the firm’s stance. Importantly, however, the effects of pro-attitudinal messaging are on par with the effects of ideologically neutral messaging. If firms wish to drum up political engagement with limited backlash, the most efficacious strategy is therefore to talk about political issues without taking a stance on them. We further show that corporate activism can even exert spillover effects on public-facing forms of participation out-

side the workplace. If companies can use their influence over employees to change their political behaviors, this would suggest an important tactic available to corporations in the *Citizens United* era—the ability to mold the contours of political participation merely by exercising their right to corporate speech.

Corporate Political Activism

Social scientists have long considered the workplace a key arena for democracy and politics in the United States (e.g. Verba et al. 1995). Employers often seek to shape the political behavior of their workers, whether at the behest of politicians or in pursuit of policies that would bode favorably for their business interests. In an early, particularly brazen case, Gaventa (1982) describes how the American Association—a landholding and coal mining conglomerate—exploited Appalachian workers’ economic precarity to stifle dissent and mobilize them for political causes. But such inauspicious examples were rare; explicit political appeals by employers were historically limited by legal standards and workplace norms. Because economic dependence of workers on their employers could make coercion more likely (*National Labor Relations Board v. Gissel Packing Co.*, 395 U.S. 575, 1969), employers were only permitted to *communicate* information about policies or legislation for much of the twentieth and early twenty-first centuries; they could not *advocate* for a candidate or party, direct employees to take any political action, or hold captive-audience meetings on political topics (Frye et al. 2025; Note 2014).

Citizens United upended this status quo in 2010. By extending First Amendment protections to corporations and treating political spending as a form of speech, the case not only relaxed campaign finance restrictions, but it also enabled employers to directly support political candidates and appeal to their workers to take political action (Ansell 2025; Hertel-Fernandez and Secunda 2016). Hertel-Fernandez (2016, 2017, 2018) documents modern efforts by employers to influence the political attitudes and behaviors of employees. In some cases, firms aim to mobilize. For instance, Cintas CEO Scott Farmer sent an email to employees implying the company’s fiscal health—and thus

their jobs—would be at risk if they voted for Barack Obama’s reelection in 2012 (Jamieson 2012). In other cases, their goal is demobilization; citing disruptions stemming from political discussion, Meta informed employees in 2022 that “health matters such as vaccine efficacy and abortion, legal matters such as pending legislation, political matters such as elections or political movements, and weapon ownership and rights... can no longer be discussed” (Robison 2022). Scholars of comparative politics document similar practices in diverse contexts (Frye et al. 2014; Mares et al. 2018; Oliveros 2021).

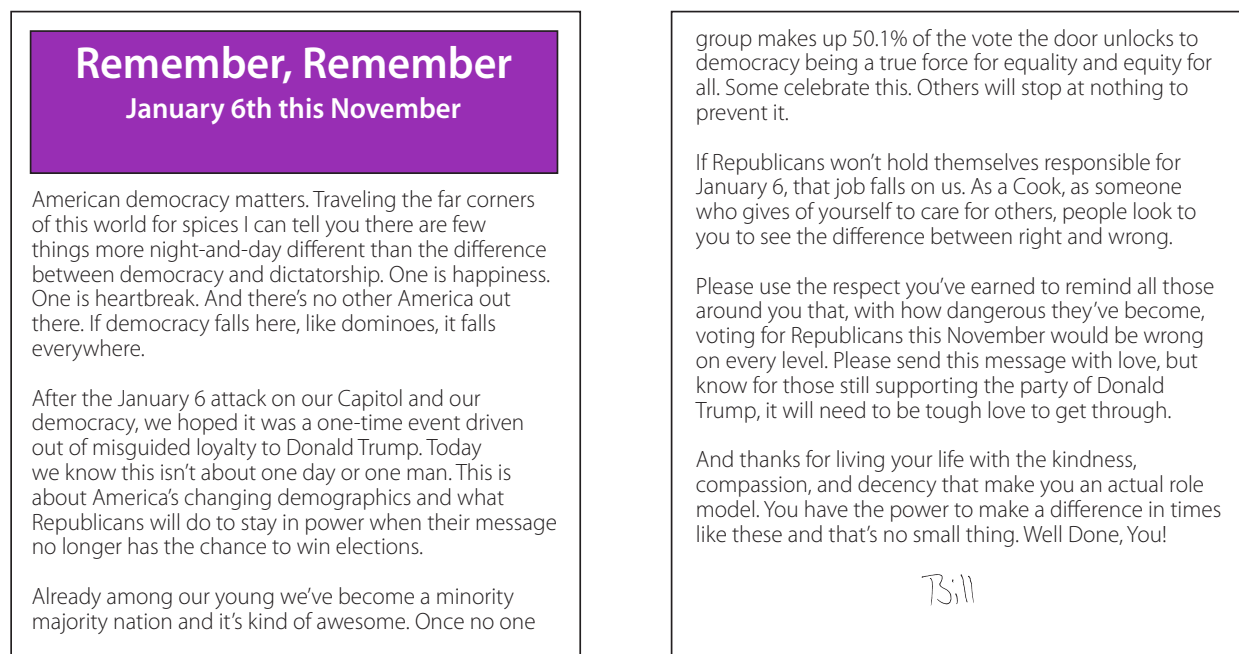


Figure 1: Card Included in “January 6” Gift Box from Penzeys Spices

We draw attention to a subtler but more public form of corporate political messaging that has become commonplace in recent years (Cassidy and Kempf 2025): using press releases, advertisements, and the like to signal positions on political issues (Bhagwat et al. 2020; Burbano 2021; Hersh and Shah forthcoming; McKean and King 2024), including social causes that seem unrelated to a firm’s bottom line. Examples of corporate political activism abound. In the months following the death of George Floyd, the fifty largest companies in the United States committed nearly \$50 billion to racial justice causes (Jan et al. 2021). The CEO of Goya Foods falsely claimed Donald

Trump won the 2020 presidential election (Salcedo 2021). In 2022, Disney publicly feuded with the Florida state government over a bill prohibiting schools from discussing gender identity (Fisch and Schwartz 2024). During election season that same year, Penzeys Spices released a “January 6” gift box, complete with a card making a not-so-subtle electoral plea to its customers, seen in Figure 1 (Penzeys Spices 2022). These examples illustrate how business leaders tend to pursue political goals by engaging with the broader public (Hersh and Shah forthcoming).

We theorize that an activism-based strategy may be more efficacious for firms than mobilizing workers directly. First, corporate activism can be financially attractive to businesses. Firms can use it to attract and retain talented workers at lower wage rates (Bode et al. 2015; Burbano 2016), spur competitors to follow suit out of perceived competitive pressure (Fisch and Schwartz 2024), and help raise capital among like-minded investors (Cassidy and Kempf 2025; Mkrtchyan et al. 2024). Second, employers must navigate the patchwork of legal gray areas that emerged in the wake of *Citizens United* (Frye et al. 2025; Hertel-Fernandez and Secunda 2016). Employee speech in non-work settings is consistently protected (Garden 2022), but restrictions on employer conduct vary across states, making heavy-handed actions risky (Burke and Lenhard 2016). Finally, overt employer mobilization—which tends to be private and clientelistic—is deeply unpopular (Hersh and Shah forthcoming). Taking coercive political actions thus risks backlash from a business’s workforce and customer base. For example, when the owner of an Ace Hardware store in California urged her employees to vote for Mitt Romney in 2012, she was met with negative publicity and a customer boycott (Chun 2012).

In contrast, the public-facing nature of corporate activism carries a pretext of innocence; it allows employers to communicate preferences to both employees and the public under the guise of taking social responsibility or positioning their brand in response to market demands (Fisch and Schwartz 2024). Such actions are less likely to be perceived as coercive because they do not directly request action from employees or threaten negative consequences for non-compliance. Instead, they can be passed off as attempts to drum up support for important causes among the general public.

Curiously, however, such activism has little influence on *consumers'* political attitudes. Marsh and Peterson (2026) show through three experiments that exposure to corporate political messaging on transgender and abortion issues can increase support for corporate political engagement among those who already agree with the stance communicated by the firm, but the messaging has no effect on subjects' issue positions themselves. To the degree that firms use political activism to appeal to consumers, it is likely due to its propensity to increase consumption among likeminded individuals (Conway and Boxell 2026). In addition to this profit-maximizing incentive, we argue that corporate activism is also important to firms because it can shape their employees' engagement with politics.

Effects of Corporate Activism on Political Participation

How do these corporate actions shape employees' political participation? We primarily focus on one particular form of participation: employees' willingness to discuss politics at work (Phillips 2026). Early theories of public opinion identified political talk in the workplace as important for the development of political attitudes and behaviors. The sociological model of voting placed great emphasis on the social environments in which citizens spent their time (Berelson et al. 1954). Because social and occupational status were viewed as crucial determinants of political attitudes in the mid-century United States (Katz and Lazarsfeld 1955), workplaces were integral to understanding how one's social environment structured one's attitudes. The social-psychological model placed less emphasis on such social structures, but still allowed for relationships among coworkers to affect the formation and change of political attitudes (Campbell et al. 1960).

The decline and political homogenization of civil society organizations in the United States has made the workplace even more valuable to contemporary civic life (Putnam 2000). Citizens typically avoid talking politics when they expect to disagree with their interlocutors (Gerber et al. 2012), instead prioritizing the maintenance of social relationships that could be damaged by interpersonal conflict (Carlson and Settle 2022). But this ability to self-select in or out of interactions is drastically reduced in the involuntary collectives of workplaces, where individuals have little

freedom to choose their interlocutors or to physically remove themselves from undesirable interactions (Cramer Walsh 2004). The “water cooler discussions” at work therefore tend to be more politically heterogeneous than discussions among friends or family (Mutz 2006), and the social pressure experienced in such settings can push citizens to engage in politics (Abrams et al. 2011).

In fact, work is one of the main environments where Americans still participate in in-person conversation across political, racial, or other demographic lines (Conover et al. 2002; Mutz and Mondak 2006; Wyatt et al. 2000). Such political talk (or lack thereof) can impact citizens’ political attitudes and behavior, enhancing political knowledge (Eveland 2004), increasing political trust (Geurkink et al. 2024), and even changing attitudes and vote intentions (Kitschelt and Rehm 2014; Phillips 2026; Ryan 2011).

We argue corporate political activism can have a mobilizing effect on employees’ willingness to discuss politics at work. By publicly indicating a firm’s stance on political issues, firms indirectly signal that political topics are acceptable in the workplace. This normalizes and encourages political talk by lowering the perceived social costs of engaging in discussion. However, we also expect these effects to be conditional on the employer’s message and its congruence with employees’ preexisting attitudes.

Mobilization is likely to be strongest when employees perceive alignment between their own attitudes or identities and the firm’s political stance (Burbano 2021; Frye et al. 2025). This expectation emerges from long-standing theoretical frameworks on social identity and value congruence. Individuals derive meaning, self-esteem, and behavioral guidance from membership in socially salient groups (Tajfel and Turner 1979), including political parties (Huddy et al. 2015; Iyengar and Westwood 2015; Nelson and Garst 2005). Consequently, social identity can affect individuals’ attitudes and actions at work through “value congruence” (Ashforth and Mael 1989). According to value congruence theory, messages are most mobilizing when they resonate with recipients’ pre-existing identities, values, and self-conceptions (Edwards and Cable 2009; Oyserman and Destin 2010).²

²In political contexts, these conditions can be overcome in some cases, such as those generating anxiety (e.g. Mehlhaff et al. 2024). We contend only that the general pattern is one of congruence enhancing responsiveness.

When employees perceive alignment with their employer or direct supervisors, they tend to trust the organization more, display greater commitment to their employer, and—most important for our purposes—be more willing to engage in expressive or participatory behaviors. By contrast, misalignment can generate feelings of alienation, withdrawal, or self-censorship (Burbano 2021; Kristof 1996; Kristof-Brown et al. 2005). Shared values not only motivate employees but also signal which behaviors are sanctioned by the employer or safe within a given workplace environment.

Identity and value congruence are thus key pathways through which social and political signals mobilize and demobilize in an organizational setting (You et al. 2026). Although corporate activism can impact employees' political attitudes (Chatterji and Toffel 2019), participation can happen even in the absence of attitude change. Corporations are more likely to influence employees' political participation when they have a mechanism to monitor compliance and employees are more likely to follow their employers' guidance when they are financially vulnerable (Hertel-Fernandez 2018), suggesting behavioral change may be driven by coercion as much as persuasion.

Theoretical Expectations

When it comes to their involvement in corporate political activism, firms have three options: they can avoid political topics altogether; they can acknowledge political issues without taking a stance; or they can take a position on one side of the issue, thus making their stances identity-congruent for some employees and identity-incongruent for others. We expect each option to have different effects on employees' willingness to engage in politics.

When firms make politically neutral statements that acknowledge an issue but do not advocate a particular position on it, we expect that action to normalize discussion of politics at work by modeling non-conflictual political discourse and signaling that the firm will not punish political speech. We also expect such statements to have similar effects among all employees regardless of political predispositions, as remaining neutral would avoid discouraging participation for anyone who might disagree with one position or another.

It is worth noting a noncommittal position can still be interpreted as political; employees may take inaction as a sign of support for the status quo, they may assume ideology based on the valence of the issue, or they may interpret a noncommittal message as reason to reinforce their prior beliefs. By defining “neutrality” as the lack of explicit position-taking, we may therefore be more cleanly identifying a lack of corporate activism on a particular issue as opposed to a lack of perceived ideology entirely.

By contrast, when firms mention a political issue *and take a stance* on it, the firm conveys to its employees that there is a particular position that is desired or aligned with corporate priorities. We expect these types of statements to have countervailing effects on employees’ willingness to engage in politics. On one hand, they may encourage individuals whose view on the issue aligns with the corporation to participate in discussion because they feel supported by the firm. On the other hand, they may discourage individuals who disagree with the corporation’s position from speaking about politics out of fear of conflict, ostracization, or negative career consequences.

Finally, the effects of corporate activism may not dissipate when employees clock out for the day. We expect corporate activism to affect forms of political participation that occur outside the workplace, such as posting on social media or writing to one’s representative in Congress (Selenko et al. 2025; Wowak et al. 2022). However, we also expect political discussion at work will be affected more strongly than other forms of participation such as discussing politics with friends and family. Workplaces are involuntary collectives where employees have limited ability to self-select in or out (Cramer Walsh 2004). Employees may therefore feel greater social pressure to conform to workplace norms and expectations regarding political talk. In contrast, individuals have more agency in choosing with whom they discuss politics outside of work, allowing them to avoid potentially contentious conversations.

Underlying this final prediction is a general expectation that corporate activism should have a greater effect on public forms of participation, as employees change their observable behavior to signal compliance with business priorities. We expect similar patterns to hold elsewhere—with respect to social media, for example. By contrast, more private forms of participation, such as

writing a letter to one's representative, are less visible to employers and coworkers and thus less likely to be used as a signal of conformity with corporate expectations.

Workers' Experiences with Corporate Activism

Before proceeding to experimental tests, we conduct preliminary examinations of our theory using observational data from an original survey of American workers. We contracted with Verasight in November 2025 to survey 3,050 American adults who were employed at least 15 hours per week in a wage-paying job.³ We first assess how frequently employees engage in political talk with coworkers, family and friends, and social media acquaintances. Figure 2 plots the proportion of respondents reporting each degree of frequency. Respondents report discussing politics with family and friends at much higher rates than other groups (consistent with Carlson and Settle 2022), while discussion with coworkers is less common; 21.5 percent say they never talk politics with coworkers, and another 37.6 percent say they do so "rarely." Rates of political talk on social media are even lower, despite most Americans encountering political content on those platforms (Pew Research Center 2016).

Political talk with coworkers is still a meaningful mode of political participation for many Americans—about forty percent engage in it regularly—but it may have nevertheless declined in prevalence over the preceding decades. Using surveys from 1984-2000, Mutz and Mondak (2006) show that political discussion at work was about as common as talk with other groups. If the general polarization of American politics since the turn of the century was primarily responsible for driving down discussion rates, we would expect talk with all interlocutors to fall similarly. Instead, we see a clear separation between talk with family and friends—which is still common—and talk with coworkers, which is less common.

Our theory suggests this divergence could result from workers reacting to increases in political actions taken by their employers. To assess this conjecture, we asked respondents whether their

³Supplementary Information (SI) section S1 presents full results in tabular form. SI section S3.1 provides the full survey instrument.

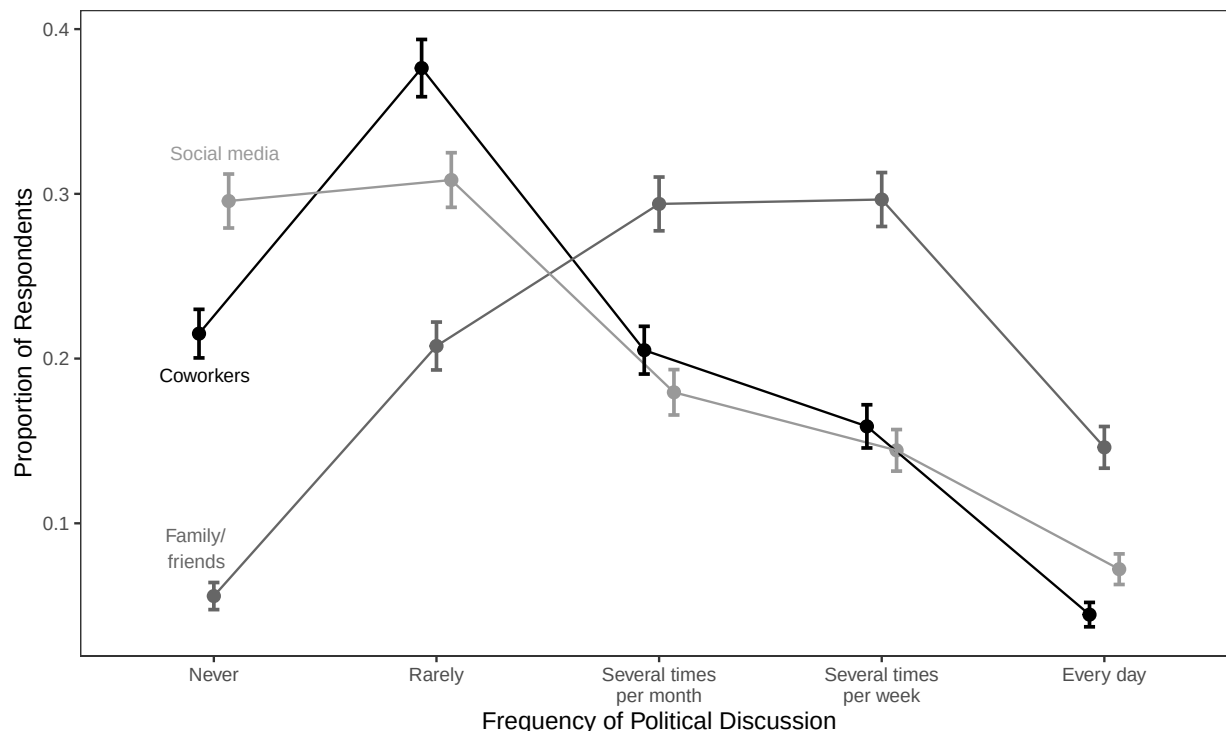


Figure 2: Frequency of Political Discussion across Groups. Error bars give 95% confidence intervals.

employer had taken a range of political actions within the previous two years. Some of these actions, such as privately advocating for a political candidate in internal communications, align more closely with the overt forms of mobilization studied by other researchers. Others are more public-facing and less blatantly coercive than vote solicitation. For instance, publicly supporting a policy or donating to a political campaign can signal an employer's preference without directly requesting action from employees.

The left facet of Figure 3 plots the proportion of respondents who reported their employer taking each form of action. We find that corporate activism is as common as more overt forms of mobilization. About 18 percent report their employer supporting a political candidate or policy in public-facing communications, with slightly fewer reporting similar statements made within the organization. Eleven percent reported that their employer had donated to a political campaign, and only five percent said their employer partnered with a political figure in advertising. Another eleven percent said their employer took some political action about which we had not asked

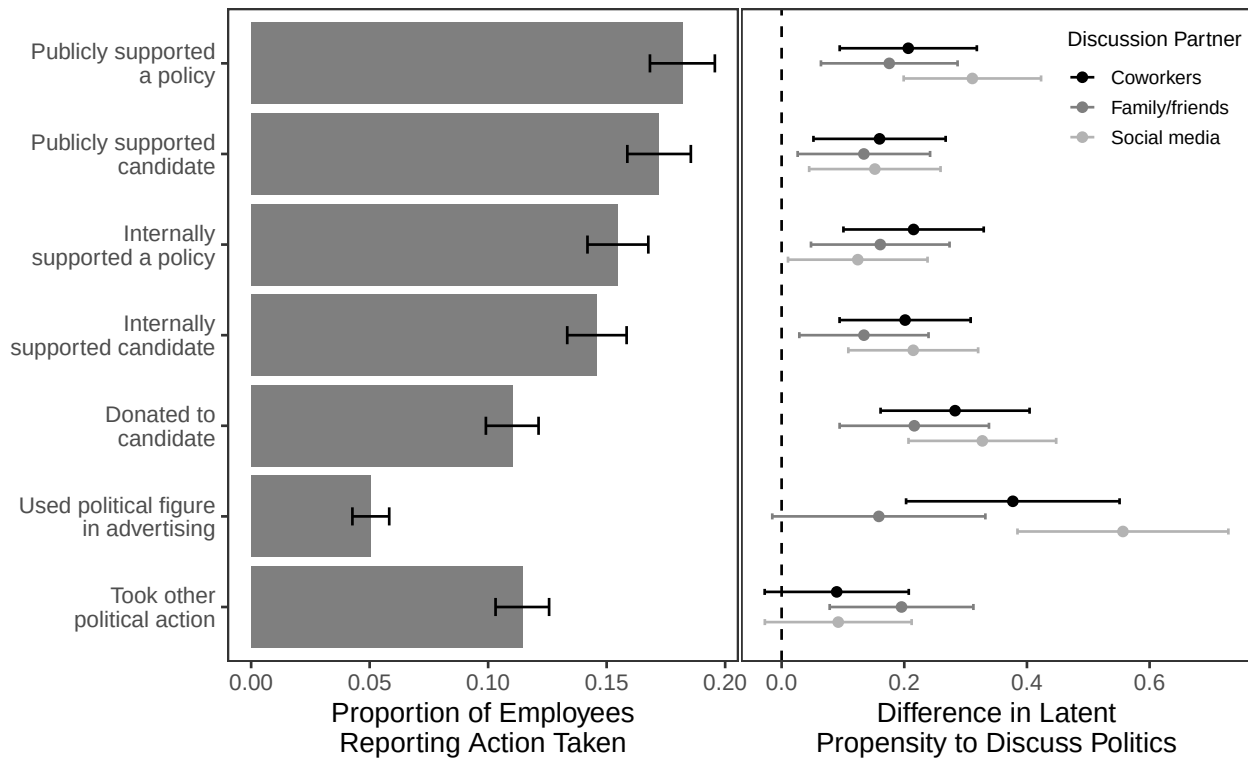


Figure 3: Prevalence and Effects of Corporate Activism. Proportion of employees reporting corporate activism in past two years (left); difference in latent propensity to discuss politics among employees experiencing corporate activism, broken down by discussion partner (right). Error bars give 95% confidence intervals. Estimates in right panel are standardized, covariate-adjusted output from ordered logit models. Full results in SI section S1.

directly.⁴ These findings are almost identical to those of Hertel-Fernandez (2018, p. 72); when asking about specific types of employer mobilization, he finds approximately fourteen percent of workers experienced them.

We also investigate the association between these corporate actions and employees' engagement in political talk. To do so, we fit a series of ordered logit regression models to the data on discussion frequency shown in Figure 2. The explanatory variables are the employer actions shown on the vertical axis of Figure 3. The right facet of Figure 3 displays the standardized difference in respondents' latent propensity to discuss politics with each group when their employer takes each action—relative to when their employer takes no action—after adjusting for covariates. We

⁴Employees may not observe all political actions taken by employers, or they may interpret innocuous actions as political. Either source of error would bias estimates of employer actions. For our purposes, what matters most is whether employees *perceive* employers as engaging in mobilization.

see consistent, positive associations between employers' political actions and employees' discussion habits, with effect sizes up to 0.5 standard deviations. Further, effects do not differ across discussion partners. This could suggest corporate activism has spillover effects on political communication outside the workplace, a contention we demonstrate causally in Study 2 below.

To dig deeper, we asked respondents seven questions capturing whether they thought political views were respected in their workplace as well as the extent to which they believed businesses should be involved in politics. We also asked respondents which party they identify with and which party they thought their managers at work identified with. Two findings in Figure 4 stand out. First, workers tend to oppose political actions by employers. Even among respondents who share their managers' party affiliation, 63.3 percent "somewhat" or "strongly agree" that businesses should stay out of politics. Among that same group, only 24.9 percent support their employer taking public stances on political issues. These responses may reflect a general opposition to *any* politics at work. 55.5 percent of ideologically cross-pressured workers and 40.2 percent of ideologically aligned workers agree that businesses should restrict political speech in the workplace, as Meta and Google have done in recent years (Elias 2024; Robison 2022). In contrast, only 19.6 percent (cross-pressured) and 31.6 percent (aligned) oppose such policies. These findings comport with existing studies showing that workers dislike employers taking political actions (Frye et al. 2025; Hersh and Shah forthcoming). In fact, such actions can actually *decrease* support for the political candidates employers are seeking to promote (Frye et al. 2025).

Second, as we theorized above, opposition to politics in the workplace is even stronger for workers who are politically cross-pressured. More than three-quarters of such respondents want businesses to stay out of politics entirely—14.4 percentage points more than workers who share their managers' party affiliation. Cross-pressured workers are also significantly more likely to feel that political diversity is not welcome at work, think that managers treat employees unequally on the basis of their political beliefs, and fear negative consequences for expressing their views. These asymmetries add important nuance to existing work demonstrating employees' distaste for employer mobilization.



Figure 4: Views of Workplace Culture Regarding Politics. Error bars give 95% confidence intervals.

One of our key theoretical expectations is that corporate activism can affect employees' likelihood of engaging their coworkers in political talk, and that those effects are conditional on employees' position within their workplace's political ecology. Building on results in Figures 2 through 4, we test this expectation by regressing respondents' frequency of political discussion with coworkers on the respondents' partisan congruence with their coworkers, managers, and corporation as a whole. Table 1 displays the quantities of interest from the ordered logit models fit on these data. In all cases, the reference category is those respondents whose party congruence is ambiguous. We control for gender, education, age, social class, race, and strength of party identity, though we present only the last of these for parsimony.

Although results support our overarching theory—that political participation in the workplace is contingent on workers' party congruence with their coworkers and overseers—we find unexpected patterns related to political counter-pressure. On one hand, sharing a party identity with one's corporation, managers, and coworkers consistently predicts increased engagement. This

Table 1: Party Congruence at Work and Political Discussion with Coworkers

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Political discussion with coworkers			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Opposite party (corporation)	0.221* (0.093)			0.172 (0.107)
Same party (corporation)	0.654* (0.081)			0.383* (0.098)
Opposite party (managers)		0.181 (0.099)		0.105 (0.121)
Same party (managers)		0.621* (0.079)		0.169 (0.102)
Opposite party (coworkers)			0.054 (0.102)	−0.058 (0.114)
Same party (coworkers)			0.718* (0.079)	0.505* (0.091)
Party strength	0.187* (0.034)	0.190* (0.034)	0.190* (0.034)	0.143* (0.035)
Demographic controls	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,980	2,973	2,974	2,968

Note: * $p < 0.05$; standard errors in parentheses.

All models are ordered logits.

points toward a mobilizing effect of corporate activism for politically like-minded workers, who may feel supported and empowered to voice their own views when they perceive alignment with those around them. On the other hand, we find no evidence that opposing the views of one's firm, managers, or coworkers has a chilling effect on political discussion. If anything, opposing the stance of one's firm is associated with *more* frequent discussion. Finding that polarizing dynamics from elsewhere in contemporary American society do not carry over into the workplace would be a valuable update to existing literature, but we must not over-claim in an observational setting. For

example, corporate activism may cause workers to sort into firms based on their politics (Frake et al. 2026; Gift and Gift 2015) and therefore shape a firm’s political composition as well as employee actions. Below, we show these relationships largely extend to causal effects.

Experimental Evidence

We conduct two experiments to test the causal effects of corporate activism on employees’ political participation. In Study 1, we find that corporate activism generally has a salubrious effect on employees’ willingness to discuss politics at work, especially when it affirms workers’ opinions on the issue. As in the descriptive survey data, we show activism has only a limited chilling effect among those who are less aligned. Most notably, we find that neutral political statements also produce a strong increase in willingness to discuss politics. In fact, the effect of neutral statements is nearly on par with that of pro-attitudinal ones. In Study 2, we show corporate activism affects political discussion at work more than other forms of participation that occur outside the workplace, but that activism can nevertheless shape employees’ political engagement more broadly. Like in Study 1, we find asymmetric effects in line with the value congruence theory we proposed above: Workers who share the corporation’s political stance are likely to change their political behaviors both in and out of the workplace, while effects on counter-pressured workers are limited. Again, politically neutral statements also increase political participation, though their effects are more modest than those of pro-attitudinal messages.

Experimental Design

Both studies employed four-arm, non-factorial experiments, with subjects assigned to each treatment arm in equal proportions.⁵ We restrict our samples to gainfully employed American adults, as those are the people most likely to be deeply embedded within the workplace, invested in a career in their current industry of employment, and dependent on their employer for salary, benefits,

⁵See SI section S2.1 for sample sizes, statistical power, and links to each study’s pre-registration.

and the like. We further aim to meet Census benchmarks on gender, age, race, and income, but we relax our quotas on income to account for the fact that subjects in the lowest income brackets are likely to be screened out by our employment requirement.

Subjects begin the study by providing information about the industry and occupation in which they work.⁶ They then respond to pre-treatment dependent variable items. Since the precise items differ across the two studies, we describe them in the respective sections below. Next, we identify the political issue that is most important to each subject, and about which they are therefore likely to hold the strongest attitudes. In most behavioral studies, researchers select one or two issues around which to build the experiment. These popular designs hold the *issue* constant across subjects, but not the *importance* of that issue to each subject (e.g. Ryan and Ehlinger 2023). This unobserved heterogeneity imposed by the design can distort estimates of average causal effects (Velez and Liu 2025).

Instead, we use an attitude elicitation task from Velez and Liu (2025) in which subjects describe a political issue about which they care deeply and provide their position on that issue in an open-ended format. This information is used later by a large language model to generate a treatment that is uniquely relevant to each subject.⁷ Subjects respond to batteries designed to estimate their levels of agreeableness and conflict avoidance, as well as a standard set of demographic items, before proceeding to the treatment.

All treatment stimuli are generated using a call to OpenAI’s GPT-4o with three pieces of information: the subject’s industry of employment, the issue they identified as being important to them, and their position on that issue. In each treatment arm, GPT-4o generates a one-paragraph public statement from a business in the subject’s industry, designed to mimic statements that might be actually released by real companies.⁸ All names of companies or corporate executives included in the generated statements are fabricated.

⁶SI sections S3.2 and S3.3 present full survey instruments.

⁷SI section S2.2 validates the output of this task.

⁸We built redundancies into the pipeline to salvage any cases where GPT-4o experienced technical issues, but these redundancies were never needed.

Subjects in the control condition read a statement about recent activities undertaken by the firm, such as a new product or last quarter's earnings report. We use this condition to provide an ostensibly non-political baseline. Subjects in the "neutral" condition read a statement in which the business discusses the subject's preferred political issue but avoids taking a stance on it or using language that explicitly signals political ideology. We use this condition to assess how subjects' willingness to discuss politics may be affected by the mere mention of politics (Bondi et al. 2025), which citizens often imbue with a sense of conflict (Groenendyk and Krupnikov 2021). We then include "pro-attitudinal" and "counter-attitudinal" conditions, in which the firm takes a stance on the issue that is either consonant or discordant, respectively, with the subject's pre-treatment position. Supplementary Information (SI) section S2.3 presents balance tests, section S2.4 provides illustrative examples of treatment stimuli in each condition, and manipulation checks in section S2.5 show the treatments were successful in cueing the intended corporate stances.

Study 1: Corporate Activism and Political Talk

We first assess the overall effect of corporate position-taking on employees' willingness to discuss politics at work, administering Study 1 to 2,200 subjects from the CloudResearch Connect panel. After reading the corporate statement that comprises our treatment, subjects respond to two dependent variable items. First, we ask subjects whether they would be willing to participate in a follow-up study where they will discuss their preferred political issue in a virtual chat with a worker from the business that purportedly produced the statement. We view this as a higher-stakes decision for subjects; choosing whether to come face-to-face with a colleague in their industry to discuss a political issue more closely approximates the decisions employees must make in their own workplaces. Second, we ask subjects how often they would discuss politics with their coworkers if they were to take a job at the firm that produced the statement. This item elicits a more hypothetical consideration, but one that nevertheless helps us capture behavioral preferences.

This dual-variable design enables us to test our hypotheses in three different ways, all of which we pre-registered. The binary behavioral measure lends itself to a simple difference-in-means

test and a quasi-repeated measures design (Mutz 2011), in which we use logistic regression to control for pre-treatment willingness to engage in political discussion at work. The Likert-style self-reported attitude item facilitates a repeated measures test, which we conduct with a difference-in-differences estimator.

Figure 5 shows the effect of each treatment on subjects' willingness to discuss politics at work. Since most of our hypotheses are directional, we plot 90% confidence intervals to facilitate one-tailed hypothesis tests at the pre-registered $\alpha = 0.05$ level. These intervals are represented by the thick error bars in Figure 5. We also provide 95% confidence intervals, represented by the thin error bars, which correspond to two-tailed tests at the same significance level.

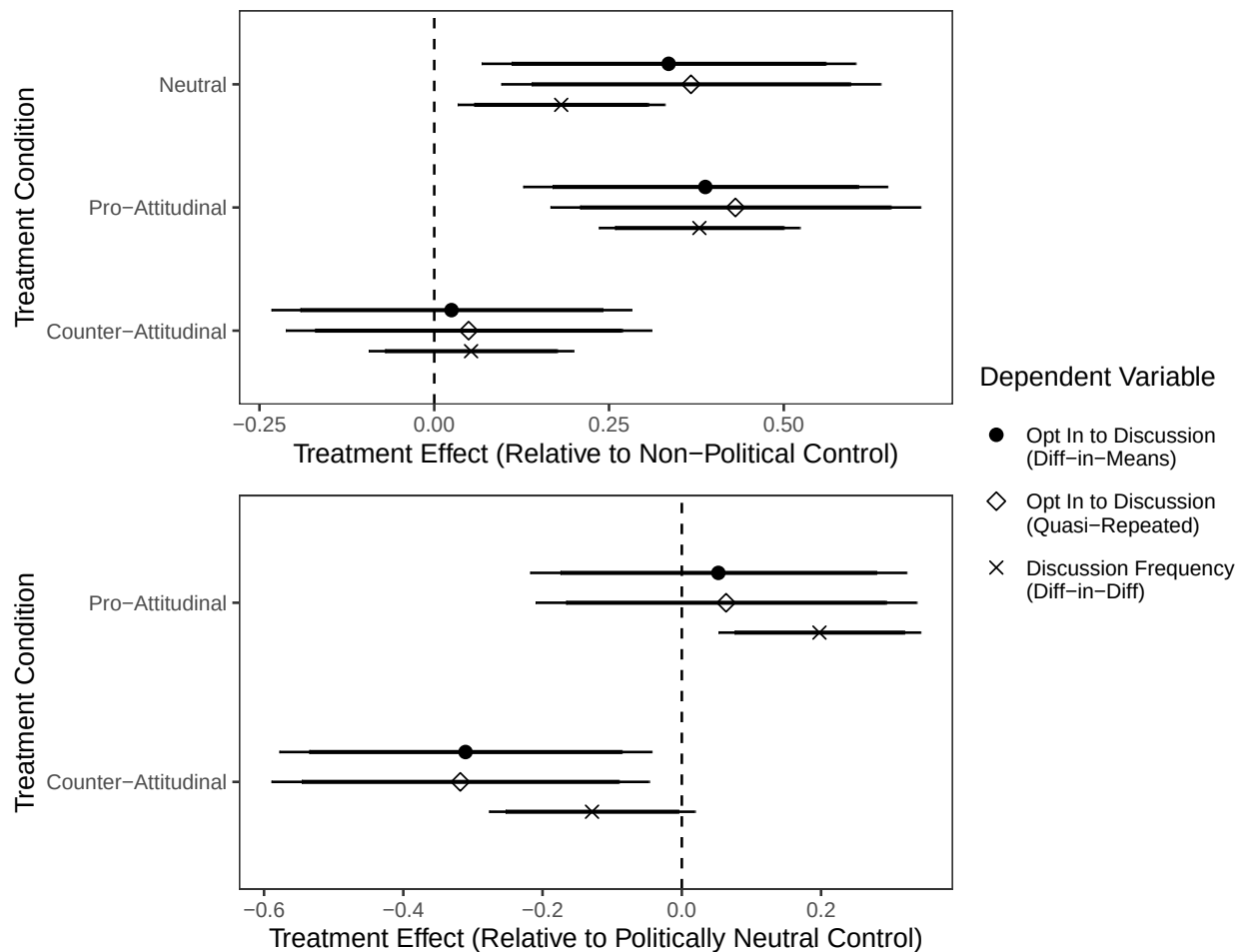


Figure 5: Effect of Treatment on Willingness to Discuss Politics, Relative to Non-Political (Top) and Neutral (Bottom) Controls. Thick and thin error bars give 90% and 95% confidence intervals, respectively. Full tabular results in SI section S2.6.

The top plot in Figure 5 provides treatment effect estimates relative to the control and the bottom plot compares pro- and counter-attitudinal estimates to the neutral condition. Our three analyses are differentiated by shape. Difference-in-means and quasi-repeated measures tests apply to the binary behavioral dependent variable and are interpretable in terms of percentage points. The difference-in-differences test applies to the self-reported attitude variable and is interpretable in terms of standard deviations. Results are similar across all analyses, although the repeated measures test tends to produce smaller standard errors, as expected.

Relative to the non-political control, politically neutral statements have a positive effect on employees' willingness to discuss politics in the workplace, increasing intended discussion frequency by 0.153 standard deviations and willingness to chat with an employee by up to 36.7 percentage points.⁹ These results suggest that corporations can promote political talk among employees by simply signaling that politics is an appropriate topic in the workplace.

Pro-attitudinal statements also produce positive effects. The two binary dependent variable tests are nearly identical to the neutral condition, while the effect estimated by the difference-in-differences model nearly doubles in magnitude. Somewhat contrary to expectations, corporate statements had no effect on discussion intentions when they ran counter to subjects' stated attitudes.¹⁰ Examining results for pro- and counter-attitudinal statements holistically, however, still provides some support for our theory of value congruence; despite having null effects relative to the control, counter-attitudinal statements still produce less political talk than pro-attitudinal ones do.

These countervailing effects are clearer when comparing pro- and counter-attitudinal statements to politically neutral (instead of non-political) ones. As seen in the bottom plot of Figure 5, when subjects were randomly assigned to read a corporate statement that went against their pre-treatment attitudes, they were about 31 percentage points less likely to volunteer to engage in a

⁹SI section S2.6 contains full results in tabular form, including *p*-values calculated using permutation tests to relax functional form assumptions about our discrete dependent variables.

¹⁰While it is possible that we could be running into a floor effect, Figure 2 suggests political talk at work still has plenty of room to move.

conversation with an employee on the topic of the statement. The self-reported attitudes test shows an even clearer contrast, with a total difference of 0.276 standard deviations.

In sum, Study 1 suggests the potential for corporate activism to divide workplace political talk by ideology, where employees who feel supported by their employer are more likely to speak out while those who feel counter-pressured change their participation little. The downstream effect of this asymmetric mobilization is that the political views expressed in the workplace will not be representative of those actually held by employees. In SI section S2.8, we show that these treatment effects are not moderated by any pre-treatment variables, including conflict avoidance, party ID strength, and demographic characteristics.

Study 2: Effects on Participation Outside the Workplace

Study 1 established that corporate activism can affect employees' willingness to discuss politics at work, and that these effects are at least partially conditional on value congruence between employees and employers. We cannot tell, however, whether corporate activism affects employees' political participation more broadly or whether there is a particular feature of the workplace environment that helps drive the effect on political talk at work. In Study 2, we seek to understand whether corporate activism has spillover effects on political participation outside the workplace. We use the same experimental design as in Study 1 but modify our dependent variables. Study 2 enlists 1,999 subjects, again from CloudResearch Connect. Subjects who participated in Study 1 were ineligible for Study 2.

We ask subjects how likely they would be to take a range of actions if they took a job at the firm that produced the statement they read. In addition to discussing the political issue with coworkers at the fictional business, we also asked how likely subjects would be to discuss the issue with family and friends, post about the issue on social media, write a short letter to their Congressional representative explaining their opinion on the issue, vote in the upcoming national

election, and donate to non-profit organizations that share their opinion on the issue.¹¹ Expanding the menu of political actions enables us to benchmark the effect of activism on workplace actions against similar actions occurring outside the workplace. Like in Study 1, we estimate treatment effects using regression to control for subjects' pre-treatment willingness to engage in each political action.

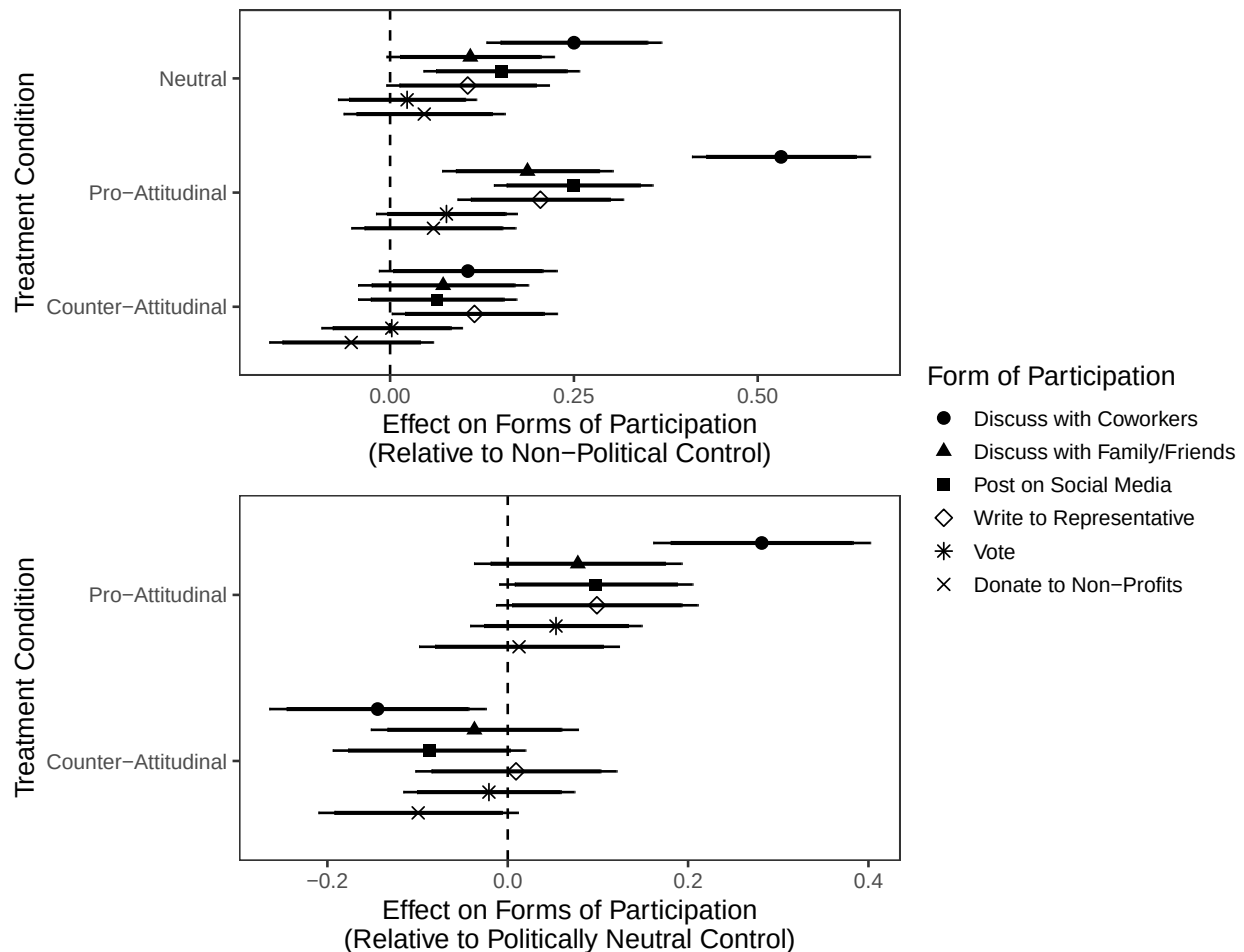


Figure 6: Effect of Treatment on Forms of Political Participation, Relative to Non-Political (Top) and Neutral (Bottom) Controls. Thick and thin error bars give 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Full tabular results in SI section S2.7.

Figure 6 shows the effect of each treatment on subjects' willingness to engage in each political action, which are represented by different shapes. As in Figure 5, thick and thin error bars give

¹¹After fielding the study, we noticed a typographical error in one of the answer choices. In SI section S2.7.1, we present a supplementary study suggesting this error was unlikely to distort our results.

90% and 95% confidence intervals, respectively, to facilitate one- and two-tailed hypothesis tests at the $\alpha = 0.05$ level. The top plot provides treatment effect estimates relative to the control, and the bottom plot provides estimates relative to the politically neutral condition. Variables are standardized and models estimated with OLS, so effect sizes are interpretable in terms of standard deviations.

The results generally replicate our findings from Study 1 and provide additional support for the notion that corporate activism has a mobilizing but asymmetric effect on employees' political talk at work. Relative to the non-political control, neutral statements increase subjects' engagement with coworkers by 0.25 standard deviations. Effects of pro-attitudinal statements are more than double that, a larger difference than in Study 1.¹² Relative to the neutral condition, pro-attitudinal statements still have a strong positive effect on discussion with coworkers, while counter-attitudinal statements have a slightly smaller—but still statistically significant—negative effect.

We also find some evidence of spillover effects on political participation more broadly. Politically neutral statements increase subjects' likelihood of discussing politics with family and friends, posting about the issue on social media, and writing to one's representative. The same is true of pro-attitudinal statements, though the effect on discussion with family and friends is statistically significant only when compared to the non-political control. Counter-attitudinal statements' effects on other dependent variables are generally null. Nevertheless, compared to the neutral condition, effect estimates for many dependent variables are of notable magnitude and in the expected direction—positive for pro-attitudinal statements and negative for counter-attitudinal ones. This divergence is suggestive of the possibility that corporate activism may have a polarizing effect on political participation outside the workplace.

In most cases, the effect of corporate activism on likelihood of discussing politics with coworkers outstrips its effect on all other forms of participation. We previously speculated that workers may feel particular pressure to participate in (or abstain from) political actions that could be considered more public in nature. If an employee suspects their manager or even corporate leaders could

¹²Full tabular effects are presented in SI section S2.7, including p -values calculated using permutation tests.

catch wind of their political views and actions, they may be especially likely to toe the company line or refrain from participation entirely (Hertel-Fernandez 2018). Through this lens, it makes sense that we observe stronger treatment effects on discussion with coworkers, discussion with family and friends, and posting on social media—all actions about which an employer could learn through surveillance or word-of-mouth. By contrast, writing to one’s Congressional representative, voting, and donating to non-profit organizations tend to be more private actions and could even be undertaken anonymously (cf. Stuckatz 2022). The more muted effects we see for those dependent variables may reflect the fact that subjects are less likely to expect either reward or blowback from their employers for engaging in such actions.

Discussion

Our descriptive survey data and experimental studies of American workers reveal three main insights into corporate political activism and patterns of political participation. First, corporate activism shapes employees’ propensity to engage their coworkers in political talk. Our finding that positional statements do not reduce willingness to participate in discussion suggests that a firm’s public engagement with a political issue—regardless of the position taken—communicates that political topics are appropriate in the workplace, thereby lowering perceived social costs of expression.

Second, this mobilization is asymmetric, concentrated among workers whose views align with their employer’s stance. The effect of asymmetric mobilization is to produce a distorted representation of employees’ political views. The workplace has historically been valued as a setting in which Americans regularly encounter political outgroup members—a source of exposure that has gained value as residential sorting and media fragmentation have reduced cross-cutting contact elsewhere (Mutz and Mondak 2006). To the extent corporate activism selectively mobilizes ideological allies while chilling—or at least not facilitating—the expression of dissenters, it risks eroding precisely the form of political interaction that makes workplaces democratically valuable.

Moreover, this normatively undesirable outcome may attain even in the absence of occupational sorting (e.g. Frake et al. 2026).

Our observational data provide additional perspective from the employees' vantage point. Workers who are politically cross-pressured relative to their managers express greater fear of retaliation, perceive their workplaces as less welcoming of political diversity, and are more likely to endorse the view that businesses should stay out of politics entirely. Yet the same workers do not substantially reduce their observed frequency of political discussion at work. One possible explanation could be that any chilling effects of counter-attitudinal corporate speech primarily operate on affect rather than behavior; cross-pressured employees may become more anxious about political talk without immediately withdrawing from it. Whether that anxiety accumulates over time to produce behavioral change, or whether it affects the quality and candor of the discussions that do occur, are important questions for future work.

Third, the effects of corporate political speech are not confined to the workplace; activism also shapes employees' likelihood of engaging in political participation outside work, especially for forms of participation that employers can plausibly observe. These spillover effects are consistent with the idea that employers can mobilize civil society, activating political identities and lowering psychological barriers to participation beyond the firm (Hertel-Fernandez 2018; Stuckatz 2022). To the extent this behavior occurs outside the workplace, it signals firms' potential to make in-kind contributions to their preferred political causes. Even in a post-*Citizens United* era, corporations need not expend large sums of money to have an impact on the political sphere—they can nudge their employees to do it for them.

Within this pattern, effects on workplace discussion consistently outstrip effects on other forms of political participation. The involuntary nature of workplace social networks may amplify this asymmetry (Cramer Walsh 2004); unlike friendships, work relationships cannot be easily curated to minimize ideological friction, so corporate messaging carries an outsized influence on the perceived norms and costs of political talk in those relationships. The fact that treatment effects are strongest precisely where political discussion is currently least common—among coworkers—

suggests that corporate activism has the potential to meaningfully reshape patterns of political interaction.

We see several avenues for future research. Our experiments abstract away from the social dynamics that shape real workplace political interactions. Because most employees occupy a subaltern role and frequently do not share the same social group memberships as their superiors, the power dynamics and identity relationships between workers and management may condition the effects of corporate messaging. Future work should examine how source characteristics—perceived identity of corporate leadership, social distance between employees and executives, and whether messaging arrives from direct supervisors or distant executives—moderate the effects documented here (Frye et al. 2025). Employees who are more financially vulnerable or lack alternative employment options might also be especially sensitive to corporate political cues (Hertel-Fernandez 2018).

We also use a fictional firm in an anonymous survey setting, which removes the economic coercion that features in prior work on employer mobilization. Real-world effects could be driven by fear of retaliation or by the legitimating and signaling functions of corporate speech; we are unable to distinguish between the two pathways here. In addition, we present a single corporate message in isolation, whereas real employees receive multiple, potentially conflicting political signals from employers, coworkers, and the media environment. Understanding how cumulative and competing signals interact to shape political behavior represents an important direction for future research. Finally, political party is not the only group delimiter that weighs on political participation. To the extent our findings also vary along demographic lines, they promise to contribute to important literatures on race, ethnicity, and political behavior (Carlson et al. 2020). As the workplace risks becoming yet another arena where partisan sorting shapes democratic discourse, corporate political speech functions not only as expressive activity but as a mechanism of selective mobilization with consequences that extend beyond the firm.

References

- Abrams, Samuel, Torben Iversen, and David Soskice (Apr. 2011). “Informal Social Networks and Rational Voting.” *British Journal of Political Science* 41.2, pp. 229–257.
- Ancell, Aaron (Mar. 2025). “Compelled Speech at Work: Employer Mobilization as a Threat to Employee Speech Rights.” *Philosophy of Management* 24.1, pp. 55–71.
- Ashforth, Blake E. and Fred Mael (Jan. 1989). “Social Identity Theory and the Organization.” *Academy of Management Review* 14.1, pp. 20–39.
- Berelson, Bernard R., Paul F. Lazarsfeld, and William N. McPhee (1954). *Voting: A Study of Opinion Formation in a Presidential Campaign*. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press.
- Bhagwat, Yashoda et al. (Sept. 2020). “Corporate Sociopolitical Activism and Firm Value.” *Journal of Marketing* 84.5, pp. 1–21.
- Bode, Christiane, Jasjit Singh, and Michelle Rogan (Dec. 2015). “Corporate Social Initiatives and Employee Retention.” *Organization Science* 26.6, pp. 1702–1720.
- Bondi, Tommaso, Vanessa C. Burbano, and Fabrizio Dell’Acqua (May 2025). “When (Not) to Talk Politics in Business: Experimental Evidence.” *Strategic Management Journal* 46.5, pp. 1105–1119.
- Burbano, Vanessa C. (Aug. 2016). “Social Responsibility Messages and Worker Wage Requirements: Field Experimental Evidence from Online Labor Marketplaces.” *Organization Science* 27.4, pp. 1010–1028.
- (Feb. 2021). “The Demotivating Effects of Communicating a Social-Political Stance: Field Experimental Evidence from an Online Labor Market Platform.” *Management Science* 67.2, pp. 1004–1025.
- Burke, Lindsay B. and Robert D. Lenhard (Mar. 18, 2016). *Politics in the Workplace: A Primer for the 2016 Elections*. Corporate Counsel. URL: https://www.cov.com/-/media/files/corporate/publications/2016/03/politics_in_the_workplace.pdf (visited on 01/09/2026).
- Campbell, Angus et al. (1960). *The American Voter*. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press.

- Carlson, Taylor N., Marisa Abrajano, and Lisa García Bedolla (2020). *Talking Politics: Political Discussion Networks and the New American Electorate*. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Carlson, Taylor N. and Jaime E. Settle (2022). *What Goes Without Saying: Navigating Political Discussion in America*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Cassidy, William M. and Elisabeth Kempf (May 2025). “Partisan Corporate Speech”. Working Paper. Cambridge, MA.
- Chatterji, Aaron K. and Michael W. Toffel (June 2019). “Assessing the Impact of CEO Activism.” *Organization & Environment* 32.2, pp. 159–185.
- Chun, Janean (Nov. 13, 2012). “Jennifer Anderson, Davis Ace Hardware Owner, Apologizes For Urging Employees To Vote Romney.” *The Huffington Post*. URL: https://www.huffpost.com/entry/jennifer-anderson-davis-ace-hardware-romney_n_2118825 (visited on 01/07/2026).
- Conover, Pamela Johnston, Donald D. Searing, and Ivor M. Crewe (Jan. 2002). “The Deliberative Potential of Political Discussion.” *British Journal of Political Science* 32.1, pp. 21–62.
- Conway, Jacob and Levi Boxell (Apr. 2026). “Consuming Values”. Working Paper. Chicago. URL: https://jacob-conway.com/pdfs/consuming_values.pdf.
- Cramer Walsh, Katherine (2004). *Talking about Politics: Informal Groups and Social Identity in American Life*. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press.
- Edwards, Jeffrey R. and Daniel M. Cable (May 2009). “The Value of Value Congruence.” *Journal of Applied Psychology* 94.3, pp. 654–677.
- Elias, Jennifer (Nov. 5, 2024). “Google Curbs Politics Discussion among Employees on U.S. Election Day.” *CNBC*. URL: <https://www.cnbc.com/2024/11/05/google-curbs-politics-discussion-among-employees-on-us-election-day.html> (visited on 01/03/2025).
- Eveland Jr., William P. (Apr. 2004). “The Effect of Political Discussion in Producing Informed Citizens: The Roles of Information, Motivation, and Elaboration.” *Political Communication* 21.2, pp. 177–193.

- Fisch, Jill E. and Jeff Schwartz (2024). “How Did Corporations Get Stuck in Politics and Can They Escape?” *The University of Chicago Business Law Review* 3, pp. 325–360.
- Frake, Justin, Reuben Hurst, and Max Kagan (June 2026). “Political Segregation in the US Workplace.” *Nature Human Behaviour*.
- Frye, Timothy, Ora John Reuter, and David Szakonyi (Apr. 2014). “Political Machines at Work: Voter Mobilization and Electoral Subversion in the Workplace.” *World Politics* 66.2, pp. 195–228.
- (2025). *Workplace Politics: How Politicians and Employers Subvert Elections*. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Garden, Charlotte (May 2022). *Was It Something I Said? Legal Protections for Employee Speech*. Washington, DC: Economic Policy Institute.
- Gaventa, John (1982). *Power and Powerlessness: Quiescence and Rebellion in an Appalachian Valley*. Urbana, IL: University of Illinois Press.
- Gerber, Alan S. et al. (Oct. 2012). “Disagreement and the Avoidance of Political Discussion: Aggregate Relationships and Differences across Personality Traits.” *American Journal of Political Science* 56.4, pp. 849–874.
- Geurkink, Bram, Agnes Akkerman, and Roderick Sluiter (2024). “Developing Political Trust at Work: How Socialization Experiences in the Workplace Reduce Inequalities in Political Trust.” *Political Behavior* 46, pp. 2005–2024.
- Gift, Karen and Thomas Gift (Sept. 2015). “Does Politics Influence Hiring? Evidence from a Randomized Experiment.” *Political Behavior* 37.3, pp. 653–675.
- Groenendyk, Eric and Yanna Krupnikov (Jan. 2021). “What Motivates Reasoning? A Theory of Goal-Dependent Political Evaluation.” *American Journal of Political Science* 65.1, pp. 180–196.
- Hersh, Eitan and Sarang Shah (forthcoming). “Who Wants Stakeholder Capitalism? Public and Elite Perceptions of the Role of Business Leaders in Politics.” *Perspectives on Politics*.

- Hertel-Fernandez, Alexander (June 2016). "How Employers Recruit Their Workers into Politics—And Why Political Scientists Should Care." *Perspectives on Politics* 14.2, pp. 410–421.
- (Jan. 2017). "American Employers as Political Machines." *The Journal of Politics* 79.1, pp. 105–117.
- (2018). *Politics at Work: How Companies Turn Their Workers into Lobbyists*. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Hertel-Fernandez, Alexander and Paul M. Secunda (2016). "Citizens Coerced: A Legislative Fix for Workplace Political Intimidation Post-Citizens United." *UCLA Law Review* 64, pp. 2–16.
- Huckfeldt, Robert, Paul E. Johnson, and John Sprague (2004). *Political Disagreement: The Survival of Diverse Opinions within Communication Networks*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Huddy, Leonie, Lilliana Mason, and Lene Aarøe (Feb. 2015). "Expressive Partisanship: Campaign Involvement, Political Emotion, and Partisan Identity." *American Political Science Review* 109.1, pp. 1–17.
- Iyengar, Shanto and Sean J. Westwood (July 2015). "Fear and Loathing across Party Lines: New Evidence on Group Polarization." *American Journal of Political Science* 59.3, pp. 690–707.
- Jamieson, Dave (Oct. 25, 2012). "Cintas CEO Scott Farmer Assails Obamacare In Election Email To Employees." *The Huffington Post*. URL: https://www.huffpost.com/entry/cintas-ceo-scott-farmer-obamacare-email_n_2019292 (visited on 01/11/2025).
- Jan, Tracy, Jena McGregor, and Meghan Hoyer (Aug. 23, 2021). "Corporate America's \$50 Billion Promise." *The Washington Post*. URL: <https://www.washingtonpost.com/business/interactive/2021/george-floyd-corporate-america-racial-justice/> (visited on 01/03/2025).
- Katz, Elihu and Paul F. Lazarsfeld (1955). *Personal Influence: The Part Played by People in the Flow of Mass Communications*. New York: The Free Press.
- Kitschelt, Herbert and Philipp Rehm (Oct. 2014). "Occupations as a Site of Political Preference Formation." *Comparative Political Studies* 47.12, pp. 1670–1706.

- Kristof, Amy L. (Mar. 1996). "Person-Organization Fit: An Integrative Review of Its Conceptualizations, Measurement, and Implications." *Personnel Psychology* 49.1, pp. 1–49.
- Kristof-Brown, Amy L., Ryan D. Zimmerman, and Erin C. Johnson (June 2005). "Consequences of Individuals' Fit at Work: A Meta-Analysis of Person-Job, Person-Organization, Person-Group, and Person-Supervisor Fit." *Personnel Psychology* 58.2, pp. 281–342.
- Lyon, Melissa Arnold, Annie A. Hemphill, and Rebecca Jacobsen (Mar. 2024). "How Do Unions Create Candidates?" *Political Behavior* 46.1, pp. 209–231.
- Mares, Isabela, Aurelian Muntean, and Tsveta Petrova (July 2018). "Economic Intimidation in Contemporary Elections: Evidence from Romania and Bulgaria." *Government and Opposition* 53.3, pp. 486–517.
- Marsh, Wayde Z. C. and Jordan Carr Peterson (Jan. 2026). "Public Perceptions of Corporate Position-Taking on Abortion and Transgender Rights." *The Journal of Politics* 88.1, pp. 401–406.
- McKean, Anna E. and Brayden G. King (Dec. 2024). "When Ideologies Align: Progressive Corporate Activism and Within-Firm Ideological Alignment." *Strategic Management Journal* 45.12, pp. 2459–2518.
- Mehlhaff, Isaac D. et al. (Jan. 2024). "Where Motivated Reasoning Withers and Looms Large: Fear and Partisan Reactions to the COVID-19 Pandemic." *American Journal of Political Science* 68.1, pp. 5–23.
- Mkrtchyan, Anahit, Jason Sandvik, and Vivi Z. Zhu (Oct. 2024). "CEO Activism and Firm Value." *Management Science* 70.10, pp. 6483–7343.
- Mutz, Diana C. (2006). *Hearing the Other Side: Deliberative versus Participatory Democracy*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- (2011). *Population-Based Survey Experiments*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
- (Oct. 2025). "The Persistence of Cross-Cutting Discussion in a Politicized Public Sphere." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 122.42, e2516942122.

- Mutz, Diana C. and Jeffery J. Mondak (Feb. 2006). "The Workplace as a Context for Cross-Cutting Political Discourse." *The Journal of Politics* 68.1, pp. 140–155.
- Nelson, Thomas E. and Jennifer Garst (Aug. 2005). "Values-Based Political Messages and Persuasion: Relationships among Speaker, Recipient, and Evoked Values." *Political Psychology* 26.4, pp. 489–516.
- Note (Dec. 2014). "Citizens United at Work: How the Landmark Decision Legalized Political Coercion in the Workplace." *Harvard Law Review* 128.2, pp. 669–690.
- Oliveros, Virginia (2021). *Patronage at Work: Public Jobs and Political Services in Argentina*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Oyserman, Daphna and Mesmin Destin (Oct. 2010). "Identity-Based Motivation: Implications for Intervention." *The Counseling Psychologist* 38.7, pp. 1001–1043.
- Penzeys Spices (2022). *Remember, Remember January 6th This November*. URL: <https://www.penzeys.com/media/ngtkjhi3/peace-card-24.pdf> (visited on 01/11/2026).
- Pew Research Center (Oct. 25, 2016). *The Political Environment on Social Media*. URL: <https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2016/10/25/the-political-environment-on-social-media/>.
- Phillips, Christian Dyogi (Mar. 2026). "'Where You Stand, Depends on Where You Work': Essential Workers' Political Attitude Formation." *Politics, Groups, and Identities* 14.10, pp. 41–61.
- Putnam, Robert D. (2000). *Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community*. New York: Touchstone.
- Robison, Kylie (Dec. 6, 2022). "Meta Bans Staff from Discussing 'Very Disruptive' Topics Including Abortion, Gun Rights, and Vaccines in New 'Community Engagement Expectations'." *Fortune*. URL: <https://fortune.com/2022/12/06/meta-facebook-bans-internal-discussion-abortion-gun-rights-vaccines-roe-v-wade/> (visited on 01/03/2025).
- Ryan, John Barry (Oct. 2011). "Social Networks as a Shortcut to Correct Voting." *American Journal of Political Science* 55.4, pp. 753–766.

- Ryan, Timothy J. and J Andrew Ehlinger (2023). *Issue Publics: How Electoral Constituencies Hide in Plain Sight*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Salcedo, Andrea (Mar. 1, 2021). “Goya’s CEO Falsely Claims Trump Is the ‘Real,’ ‘Legitimate’ President. Critics Call for a Boycott.” *The Washington Post*. URL: <https://www.washingtonpost.com/nation/2021/03/01/goya-ceo-cpac-trump-boycott/> (visited on 01/03/2025).
- Selenko, Eva et al. (July 2025). “The Political Consequences of Work: An Integrative Review.” *Journal of Management* 51.6, pp. 2355–2388.
- Steel, Reilly (May 2026). “The Political Transformation of Corporate America, 2001-2022.” *American Political Science Review* 120.2, pp. 582–598.
- Stevens, Gillian and David L. Featherman (Dec. 1981). “A Revised Socioeconomic Index of Occupational Status.” *Social Science Research* 10.4, pp. 364–395.
- Stuckatz, Jan (Feb. 2022). “How the Workplace Affects Employee Political Contributions.” *American Political Science Review* 116.1, pp. 54–69.
- Tajfel, Henri and John Turner (1979). “An Integrative Theory of Intergroup Conflict.” *The Social Psychology of Intergroup Relations*. Ed. by William G. Austin and Stephen Worchel. Monterey, CA: Brooks/Cole Publishing, pp. 33–47.
- Velez, Yamil Ricardo and Patrick Liu (May 2025). “Confronting Core Issues: A Critical Assessment of Attitude Polarization Using Tailored Experiments.” *American Political Science Review* 119.2, pp. 1036–1053.
- Verba, Sidney, Kay Lehman Schlozman, and Henry E. Brady (1995). *Voice and Equality: Civic Voluntarism in American Politics*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Wowak, Adam J., John R. Busenbark, and Donald C. Hambrick (June 2022). “How Do Employees React When Their CEO Speaks Out? Intra- and Extra-Firm Implications of CEO Sociopolitical Activism.” *Administrative Science Quarterly* 67.2, pp. 553–593.
- Wyatt, Robert O., Elihu Katz, and Joohan Kim (Win. 2000). “Bridging the Spheres: Political and Personal Conversation in Public and Private Spaces.” *Journal of Communication* 50.1, pp. 71–92.

You, Leping, Linda Hon, and Yu-Hao Lee (Apr. 2026). “How Value Congruence and Issue Relevance Affect Consumer Reactions to Corporate Political Advocacy.” *International Journal of Business Communication* 63.2, pp. 432–461.